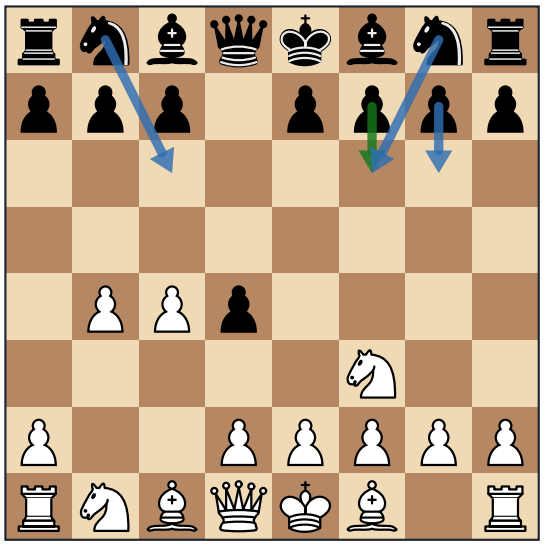
Réti Opening

ECO A09-A14 | 43 named lines | Flank openings (English, Reti, Bird, KIA)

In one sentence: Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.



Main line: 1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 3.b4

Key ideas

1. Control d5 and e5 with pawns on c4 and pieces on f3 and c3.
2. Fianchetto the king's bishop (g3, Bg2) for long-diagonal pressure.
3. Choose a center after seeing Black's setup: d4 or e4.
4. Transpose to Queen's Gambit, Catalan or Sicilian-style structures.
5. English: reversed Sicilian ideas with extra tempo.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.11** (equal, depth 16). Best: f6.

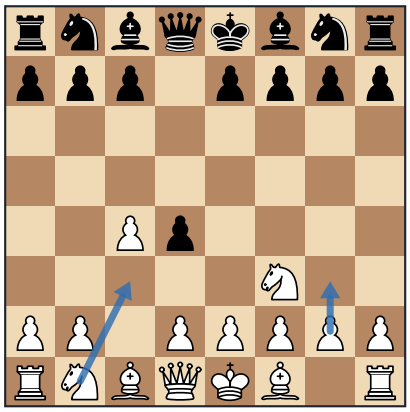
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; g3/Bg2 is a safe shelter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bg2 and Bb2 on the long diagonals, knights c3/f3, breaks with d4/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 3.b4

Move	Why it is played
1. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
1... d5	Hit c4. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. c4	Control d5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. b4	Queenside expansion. Gains space on the wing.



After 1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

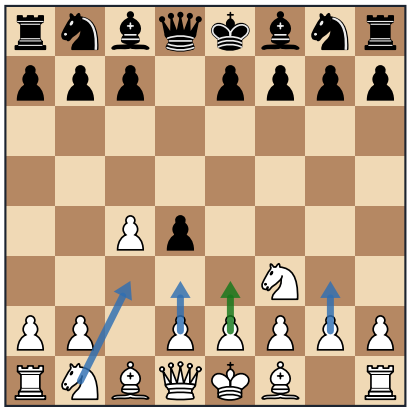


Position after the line

Anglo-Slav Variation A12 | 34 lines

`1.c4 Nf6 2.g3 c6 3.Nf3 d5 4.b3`

Stockfish: **-0.17** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Bg4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)
Sub-variations: with g3, Gurevich System, Bogoljubow Variation, London Defensive System

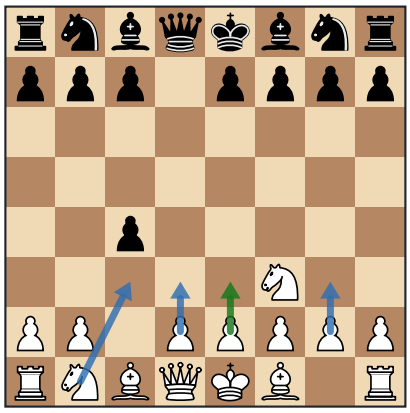


Position after the line

Advance Variation A09 | 3 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4`

Stockfish: **-0.05** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Michel Gambit, Navara Gambit

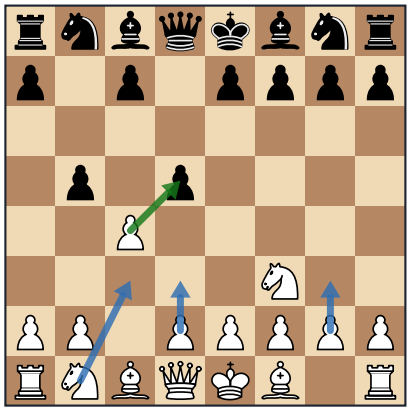


Position after the line

Réti Accepted A09 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 dxc4`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

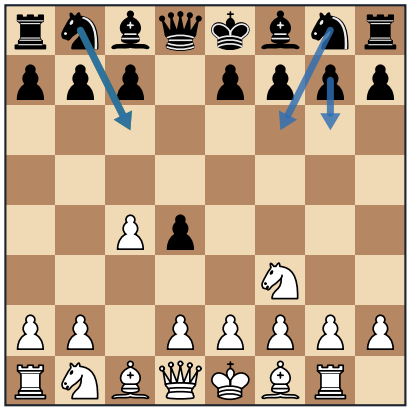


Position after the line

Zilbermints Gambit A09 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 b5`

Stockfish: **+1.53** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: cxd5.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

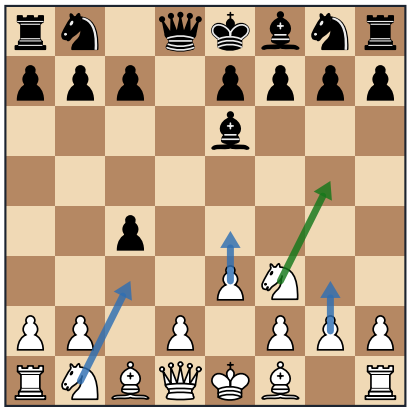


Position after the line

Penguin Variation A09 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 3.Rg1`

Stockfish: **-1.49** (clearly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Nc6.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)



Position after the line

Réti Gambit A09 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 Be6`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Ng5.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Keres Variation

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Flank openings are about flexibility, not speed. Make sure you know the main transpositions and what structures you want, then choose moves accordingly.

Why play it

Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Typical mistakes

- Being too passive and letting Black take the center for free.
- Playing d3 and e4 without a plan for the queenside pawns.
- Neglecting development while chasing a fianchetto.

Typical tactics and traps

- Early Qb3 or Qa4 pins that win the c4 or d5 pawn if Black is careless.
- Tactics on the long diagonal against b7/g7.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced, flexible endgames with minor advantages for the better-placed bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Réti Opening (all lines)** — A09
  `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4`
  - **Advance Variation** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...d4`
    - **Michel Gambit** — A09
      `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 -> 3.b4 c5`
    - **Navara Gambit** — A09
      `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 -> 3.b4 g5`
  - **Réti Accepted** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...dxc4`
  - **Zilbermints Gambit** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...b5`
  - **Penguin Variation** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...d4 3.Rg1`
  - **Réti Gambit** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...dxc4 3.e3 Be6`
    - **Keres Variation** — A09
      `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 Be6`
  - **Anglo-Slav Variation** — A12
    `1.c4 Nf6 2.g3 c6 3.Nf3 d5 4.b3`
    - **Bogoljubow Variation** — A12
      `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 c6 3.b3`
      - **Stonewall Line** — A14
        `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 e6 3.g3 Nf6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.O-O O-O 6.b3 c6 7.Bb2`
    - **Gurevich System** — A11
      `1.c4 c6 2.Nf3 d5 3.e3`
    - **with g3** — A11
      `1.c4 c6 2.Nf3 d5 3.g3 Nf6 4.Bg2`
    - **Bled Variation** — A12
      `1.Nf3 d5 2.b3 Nf6 3.Bb2 g6 4.c4 c6`
    - **Capablanca Variation** — A12
      `1.c4 Nf6 2.Nf3 c6 3.b3 d5 4.Bb2 Bg4`
    - **London Defensive System** — A12
      `1.c4 Nf6 2.g3 c6 3.Nf3 d5 4.b3 -> 4...Bf5`
    - **New York System** — A12
      `1.Nf3 Nf6 2.c4 c6 3.b3 d5 4.Bb2 Bf5`
    - **Torre System** — A12
      `1.c4 Nf6 2.g3 c6 3.Nf3 d5 4.b3 -> 4...Bg4`
    - **with dxc4** — A12
      `1.c4 Nf6 2.g3 c6 3.Nf3 d5 4.b3 -> 4...dxc4`
  - **Reversed Blumenfeld Gambit** — A09
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 -> 2...d4 3.e3 c5 4.b4`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 3.b4
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2 -> O-O
Black	e5 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> c5 -> g6

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.
2. Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
3. White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

Pawn structure in one line

Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.